UNIT 11

The Age of Revolutions

Learning Objectives

Acquainting ourselves with

- The causes, course and effects of American War of Independence
- French Revolution, its causes, course and its impact in Europe and across the world
- Revolution in Latin America
- The beginning of Industrial revolution in England and later in Germany and the USA

Introduction

At the beginning of the eighteenth century, political, religious, social and economic conditions began to change all over the world, due to geographical discoveries, the Renaissance, the Reformation and "the age of kings". By the time the eighteenth century ended, there were two revolutions: The American Revolution of 1775–83 and the French Revolution of 1789–95. These revolutions dealt a severe blow to the monarchical form of government and had a lasting impact on the subsequent history of humanity. The industrial revolution, beginning in the eighteenth century, engendered many changes in the lives of the people, heralding a new era that was marked by the shift from primarily agriculture-based economy to industry-based economy. This lesson will help us understand the aforesaid events of global importance.

11.1 The American War of Independence

During the Age of Discovery, adventurous seafarers explored the so-called New World and discovered new trade routes with royal support. This ensured better connectivity and profits. Though Spain and Portugal took the lead in exploring the new places, establishing trade centres first and later colonies, it was Britain which established colonies all over the world and successfully controlled them over a long period of time. Though the English were the first to settle in North America, in due course of time, the Germans, the Swedes, the French, the Italians and the Dutch too went to the America and settled there. The colonisation of the New World absorbed the growing population of Europe at a time of rapid economic and demographic growth.

King James I sent an expedition to Virginia where a colony was established in 1607 and named Jamestown. Then the pilgrims from Britain sailed in a ship called *Mayflower* and set up a colony at Plymouth in Massachusetts. Slowly other colonies were established. The Dutch set up a colony, in 1624, near the mouth of the River Hudson and named it New Amsterdam. Later, the English acquired it from the Dutch and renamed it New York. In the early 1700s enslaved Africans made up a growing percentage of the colonial population. By 1770, more than 2 million people lived and worked in Great Britain's 13 North American colonies.

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